

Letter from Major General Horatio Gates

to General George Washington — Extract
Hillsborough, North Carolina | September 3, 1780

MAJR. GEN. GATES TO GEN. GEORGE WASHINGTON.

[Extract of letter from Genl. Gates to Genl. Washington, Sept. 3, 1780. In Letters to Washington, No. 41, p. 247.]

Hillsborough, 3rd September, 1780.

Sir:

I had, the Day before yesterday, the honor to receive your Excellency's letter dated the 8th August, from Orange Town. It gave me infinite satisfaction to find you had baffled Sir Harry Clinton's designs, and was to all appearance in so prosperous a situation. Heaven grant you the greatest Honor and Success. As to the situation of affairs here since my last letter to your Excellency of the 30th ultimo, I can only say no considerable alteration has taken place, the Enemy remaining still and the Disaffected doing nothing of Consequence to disturb us. 1,400 of the Second Draught of the Militia of this State are marched to cover Salisbury and the country from thence to Charlotte, where Colonel Sumpter has a command, which occasionally acts upon the West Side of the Wateree, and has hitherto given such a jealousy to the British in Camden as to keep them at Home. Three hundred Virginia Riflemen under Colonel Campbell and Militia from the back Counties are marching to the East Bank of the Yadkin at the Ford, and Genl. Stevens, with what have not run home, of the other Virginia Militia, is at Guilford Court House. The Maryland division and the Artillery are here, to be refitted. The former will be put into one strong Regiment, with a good Light Infantry Company under Colo. Williams. The Rest of the Officers will be sent immediately to Maryland for the purpose directed by your Excellency in your letter to the Baron de Kalb the 27th June, which came to my hands only yesterday from Richmond in Virginia. General Muhlenberg acquaints me that near Five Hundred Regulars are upon their march from Petersburg to this place; these, with the Marylanders above mentioned, will make us stronger in Continental troops than I was before the action. The Cavalry under the Colonels White and Washington and Major Nelson are not quite equipped so as to be able to march to Rock Fish in the neighborhood of Cross Creek as I directed, but I hope they will soon be in a condition to obey my orders.

Col. Dulyson, Aid de Camp to the Baron de Kalb, a most amiable young officer, will wait upon your Excellency. He was wounded and taken, but Lord Cornwallis has permitted him to go to Philadelphia on parole. All the Baron's baggage and Papers are saved; they are delivered to Colonel Dulyson, who will be responsible for them.

Too much honor cannot be paid by Congress to the Memory of the Baron de Kalb, who was every thing an Excellent Officer should be, and in the Cause of the United States has sacrificed his life.

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HORATIO GATES.

Source: Letters to Washington, No. 41, p. 247; reprinted in the published volume of Washington-era correspondence, Vol. 15, pp. 65–66. Written from Hillsborough, North Carolina, eighteen days after Gates's army was routed at the Battle of Camden (August 16, 1780). The letter reports on the reorganization of the shattered Southern Army and conveys news of Baron Johann de Kalb, mortally wounded at Camden, whose aide-de-camp Gates is sending on to Washington.